

Daily Life in China

Opening a Bank Card in China: Complete Guide (2026)

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Opening a Bank Card in China: Complete Guide (2026)

A Chinese bank card is essential for daily life in China. Without one, you cannot fully use WeChat Pay or Alipay, receive salary payments, or pay rent. Here is everything you need to know about opening a bank account as a foreigner.

Why You Need a Chinese Bank Card:

- * Link to

- * WeChat Pay (微信支付)

- * and

- * Alipay (支付宝)

- * for seamless mobile payments

- * Receive salary payments from your employer

- * Pay rent, utilities, and online shopping

* Transfer money domestically within China

For Students (学生)

Required Documents:

* Passport

* -- with valid student visa (X1/X2)

* Student ID (学生证)

* or Enrollment Certificate (在读证明) from your university

* Temporary Residence Registration (临时住宿登记表)

* -- obtained from the local police station within 24 hours of arrival

* Admission Letter (录取通知书)

* -- required by some banks for new students

Recommended Banks for Students:

- * Bank of China (中国银行)

- * -- Best for international transfers, widely used by international students

- * ICBC (工商银行)

- * -- Largest ATM network in China, convenient for withdrawals anywhere

- * China Construction Bank (建设银行)

- * -- Good campus branch coverage at major universities

Process:

- * Go to a bank branch near your campus -- look for the foreigner service counter

(外币业务窗口)

- * Fill out the account application form (开户申请表) -- staff can assist in English at major

branches

- * Get a queue number (排队号码) and wait for your turn

- 
- * Open a basic savings account (储蓄卡/借记卡) with an initial deposit -- usually ¥10-50
 - * Set up online banking (网上银行) and mobile banking (手机银行) during the same visit
 - * Receive your UnionPay (银联) debit card on the spot in most cases

Tips for Students:

- * Bring a Chinese friend or classmate for translation -- not all branches have

English-speaking staff

- * Many universities organize
 - * group bank card opening sessions
 - * during orientation week -- take advantage of this
 - * Your card can be linked to WeChat Pay and Alipay immediately after activation
 - * Keep your bank card number (卡号) and online banking credentials in a safe place
- 

For Working Professionals (工作人士)

Required Documents:

- * Passport

- * -- with valid work visa (Z visa)

- * Work Permit (工作许可证)

- * or Employment Contract (劳动合同)

- * Residence Permit (居留许可)

- * -- issued by the local Public Security Bureau

- * Company Introduction Letter (单位证明)

- * -- a letter from your employer confirming your employment, stamped with the
company seal (公章)

- * Temporary Residence Registration (临时住宿登记表)

Additional Requirements:

- * Some banks require a
- * Chinese phone number registered to your passport
- * -- make sure your SIM card is under your own name
- * You may need to provide a
- * Tax ID (纳税人识别号)
- * -- ask your HR department for this

Recommended Banks for Professionals:

- * Bank of China (中国银行)
- * -- Best for international transfers and receiving money from abroad
- * ICBC (工商银行)
- * -- Widest ATM network across China, good for frequent travelers within the country
- * China Merchants Bank (招商银行)

* -- Best mobile banking app experience, excellent customer service

Process:

* Your employer may help arrange the bank account opening -- check with HR first

* Alternatively, go to a bank branch yourself with all required documents

* Fill out the account application and KYC (Know Your Customer) forms

* Open a

* salary account (工资账户)

* if your employer requires a specific bank for payroll

* Set up automatic salary deposit (代发工资) through your employer's payroll system

* You may qualify for a

* credit card (信用卡)

* after 6+ months of account history

International Transfers:

- * Use your bank's

- * SWIFT code

- * to receive money from abroad -- Bank of China: BKCHCNBJ, ICBC: ICBKCNBJ, CMB:

CMBCCNBS

- * The annual foreign exchange limit is

- * \$50,000 USD equivalent per person

- * Receiving money from abroad typically takes 1-3 business days

- * You will need to visit the bank counter to convert foreign currency to RMB in some

cases

Common Tips for Everyone

- * Always bring your passport -- you cannot open a bank account without it

* Bank hours:

* Monday-Friday 9:00-17:00

* , some branches open Saturday morning (9:00-12:00)

* Download your bank's

* mobile banking app (手机银行)

* for convenient transfers and balance checks

* A

* UnionPay (银联)

* card works at most ATMs and POS terminals across China

* Keep your bank card and password safe --

* never share your OTP (one-time password) with anyone

* If your card is lost or stolen, call your bank's customer service hotline immediately to

freeze the account

* Bank of China (中国银行)

* -- SWIFT: BKCHCNBJ -- Best for: International transfers

* ICBC (工商银行)

* -- SWIFT: ICBKCNBJ -- Best for: Widest ATM network

* China Construction Bank (建设银行)

* -- SWIFT: PCBCCNBJ -- Best for: Campus branch coverage

* China Merchants Bank (招商银行)

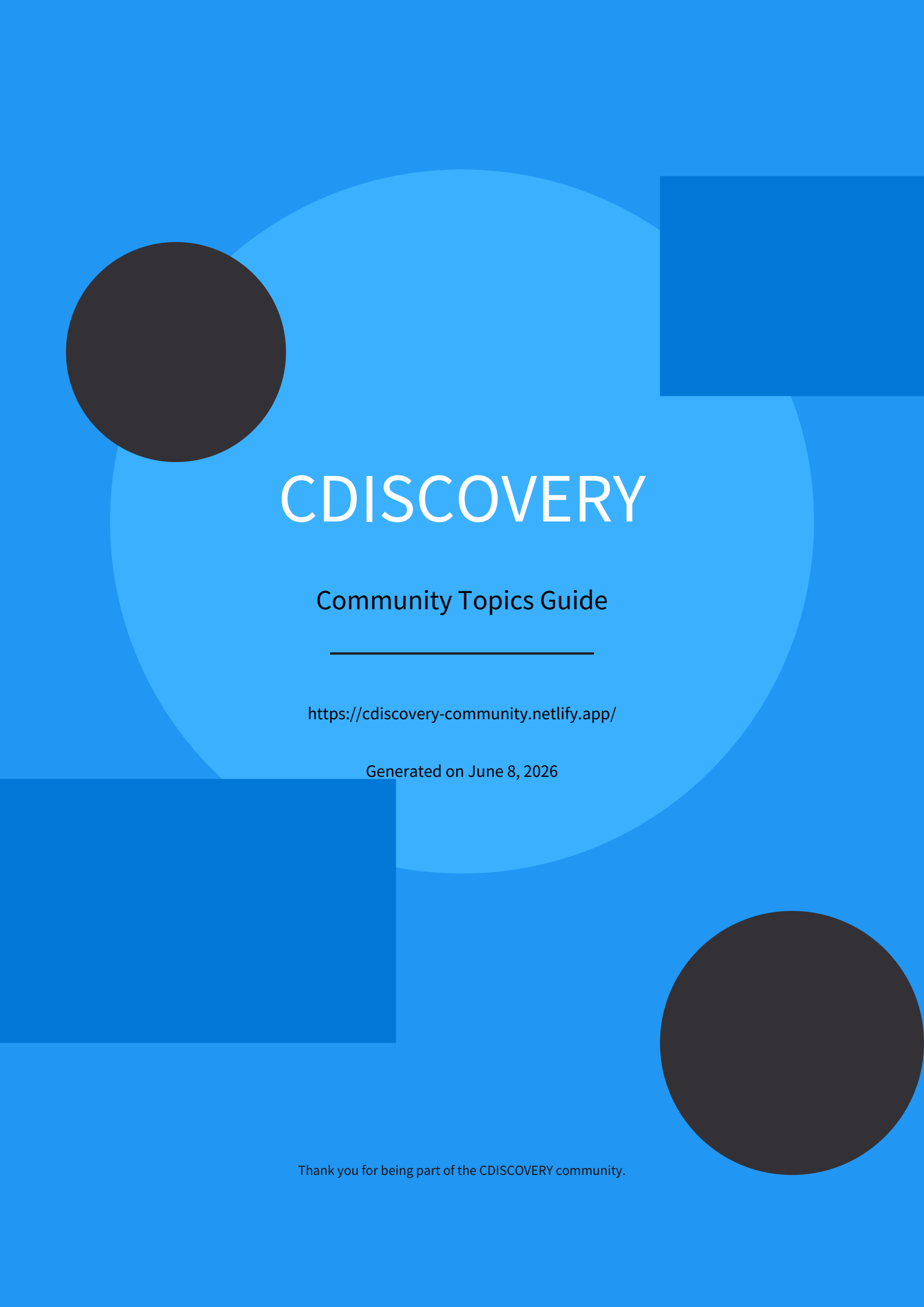
* -- SWIFT: CMBCCNBS -- Best for: Best app experience

Sources: Sources: [Bank of China](https://www.boc.cn) • [ICBC](https://www.icbc.com.cn) • [China](https://www.ccb.com)

[ICBC](https://www.icbc.com.cn) • [China](https://www.ccb.com)

Construction Bank • [China Merchants Bank](https://www.cmbchina.com) • [State Administration of Foreign Exchange](https://www.safe.gov.cn)

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